CHAPTER VIII

The Silence Beyond Illuminations

Kolkata · October 2023

“There are evenings when the world seems determined to celebrate, when streets are dressed in light and every passing face appears to belong somewhere. We move among the crowds, answer familiar voices, and find ourselves smiling at things we shall scarcely remember. Yet somewhere between one moment and the next, our thoughts return to a place we cannot reach, to questions we have no reason to ask and answers we are not certain we wish to hear. And perhaps the loneliest part of such evenings is how easily we learn to appear as though we are entirely there.”

The days following that Monday offered Utkarsh no particular reason to remember them separately.

Classes began and ended. Teachers filled the board with calculations, students complained about the approaching examinations, and the familiar noise of chairs being pushed back marked the intervals between lessons. Outside, Kolkata was preparing for Durga Puja. Temporary structures had begun appearing along the roads, bamboo frames rose behind sheets of cloth, and shopfronts displayed clothes that would remain untouched by most of the people who stopped to admire them.

Nothing in the coaching centre had changed enough to be noticed.

Sanondita still spoke to him when they sat together. She showed him things on her phone, asked for help with questions she found difficult, and occasionally borrowed his pen without waiting for permission. Utkarsh answered as he always had. He knew when to look up, when to listen, when to return his attention to the board.

Their conversations continued with an ease that would have made the preceding Monday seem unimportant to anyone watching.

Once, while the teacher worked through a lengthy calculation, Sanondita leaned towards his notebook and pointed to a step she had missed.

“How did you get this?”

He turned the page slightly towards her.

“From here,” he said, indicating the previous line. “You have to simplify this part first.”

She followed the calculation with her finger.

“Oh. I see.”

She copied the step into her notebook and resumed writing.

Utkarsh looked towards the board. The teacher had moved on to the next question, and he had missed the beginning of the explanation. He waited for the working to become familiar enough to follow.

Beside him, Sanondita turned another page.

During the break, she spoke about something that had happened at home. He listened, asked a question, and received an answer that led to another story. She laughed at her own description of it. He smiled before remembering that he had been troubled.

He had meant what he told himself on Monday. Her afternoons belonged to her; he had no wish to make her defend them. Sitting beside her again, he found that understanding this had done very little to quiet the wish to be included in them.

She reached for his pen. He moved it towards her without interrupting the story. A moment later she gave it back, still speaking. He liked being familiar enough for something to pass between them without a question. Then he found himself wondering where she would go after class, and missed the end of her sentence.

“What?” he asked.

She repeated it. He listened properly this time.

A few days before Puja, he began looking for a shirt.

He had already seen several online, none of which seemed particularly different from the others after he had spent enough time comparing them. One evening he saved a few photographs to his phone. By the following morning, he had narrowed the selection to three.

He waited until the interval between classes before showing them to Sanondita.

“Which one looks better?”

She took the phone and studied the first photograph.

“Show me the others.”

He swiped to the next.

She looked at it for a moment, then at the third.

“This one,” she said.

“The last one?”

“Yes. I like the colour.”

He looked at the screen again. It was the one he had been considering before he asked her.

She handed the phone back, then glanced at the photograph once more.

“I bought something similar for a friend.”

He kept his eyes on the screen.

“Oh. Really?”

“Yes. Almost the same.”

He moved his thumb across the photographs, returning to the first one.

“Then this one?”

She leaned closer to look.

“No. The other one was better.”

“All right.”

He saved her choice.

The next class began before either of them had anything more to say about it.

For the rest of the morning, she asked him for a page number, answered the teacher, and tried to finish a calculation before the solution appeared on the board. When she needed his notes, he moved them closer.

He did not ask which friend she had meant. The question would have been easy to put into words. He could have asked where she had bought the shirt and allowed the conversation to take him there. Instead, he kept her choice saved on his phone.

He had liked the colour before she chose it. Now he wanted to know whether she had imagined it on him, or simply recognised something she had already liked on somebody else. He could hear how foolish that distinction would sound aloud. It remained important to him anyway.

When the final class ended, Sanondita closed her notebook and began putting her things away. Utkarsh checked that he had copied the last question correctly.

“Are you going home for Puja?” she asked.

“Yes. In a few days.”

“For how long?”

“Until it’s over, probably. I’ll come back after that.”

She nodded.

“Have you bought everything?”

“Not yet.”

“The shirt?”

“Almost.”

She looked at him.

“Almost?”

“I’ve decided which one.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“I’ve done the difficult part.”

“You haven’t paid for it.”

“That’s the part I was hoping to avoid.”

She laughed. He was pleased to have found the answer before the moment passed.

She adjusted the strap of her bag and stood.

He put his notebook away, taking longer than necessary to fit it between the others.

They left the classroom together. At the point where they usually went their separate ways, she reminded him to send her the question they had discussed earlier.

“I’ll send it when I get home,” he said.

“Don’t forget.”

“I won’t.”

She left, and he remained where he was for a moment, searching his bag for the phone he already knew was in his pocket.

On the way home, he opened the photographs again.

He looked at the shirt Sanondita had chosen, checked the size, and read through the details he had already read twice.

Then he placed the order.

The confirmation appeared almost immediately. He checked the colour once more before closing the application. Whatever had made her choose it, he still wanted to wear it.

He had practice questions to finish, belongings to collect, books to decide upon. He began arranging these tasks in his mind as he walked.

At the next crossing, the traffic stopped. He stood among the waiting pedestrians while a bus passed in front of them, its windows reflecting the afternoon sun.

For a few seconds, he tried to remember whether Sanondita had said a friend or one of my friends.

The difference, he knew, would tell him nothing.

He waited for the signal to change.

By the middle of October, the approaching festival had begun to alter the rhythm of the coaching centre.

Some students had already left Kolkata. Others discussed train reservations, unfinished shopping, and the number of days they could afford to miss without falling too far behind. The teachers continued their lessons with an urgency that suggested the holidays were a personal inconvenience. A revised schedule had been circulated, though few seemed entirely certain which classes would actually take place.

Utkarsh had booked his journey home.

He had also begun deciding what to carry with him. The books were proving more difficult than the clothes. Every subject seemed important enough to deserve a place in his bag, and he knew from experience that he would return with several chapters untouched. Still, leaving them behind felt too much like admitting he would not study.

That morning, Sanondita arrived shortly before the first class.

He had been working through a set of arithmetic questions when she took the chair beside him. She placed her bag on the floor, took out her notebook, and asked whether the teacher had arrived.

“Not yet.”

She looked towards the board, where someone had written the previous day’s homework.

“Have you done those?”

“Most of them.”

“Let me see the last one.”

He turned his notebook towards her.

She studied the solution for a moment, then copied the final steps. He returned to the question he had been solving.

For a while, neither spoke.

It was during the interval after the first class that the conversation arose.

Sanondita was telling him about something that had happened to a friend. Utkarsh listened while putting his books away, occasionally looking up as she spoke. The story moved from one

detail to another, as conversations often did between them, until she mentioned that the friend had recently bought a car.

“A car?” he asked.

“Yes. Just bought it.”

He looked at her.

“Didn’t he already have a bike?”

“He does.”

She continued speaking, and Utkarsh listened.

He had no difficulty following what she said. He asked another question, received an answer, and responded in the same unhurried manner he always used with her. When the next teacher entered, they put their phones away and opened their notebooks.

The conversation ended there.

It would have been difficult for Sanondita to remember anything remarkable about it.

During the lesson, Utkarsh worked through the questions on the board. He was familiar with the method, though one calculation required him to begin again after an error in the second step. He crossed out the incorrect figures, wrote the expression beneath them, and continued.

The teacher asked the class to solve a similar question independently.

Utkarsh finished before most of the students around him.

He checked his answer.

Then he checked it again.

There was a small satisfaction in reaching the correct result, though it lasted only until the teacher began the next problem.

He wrote down the question and glanced at the clock.

There were still forty minutes left.

For some reason, he remembered the motorcycle from the photograph he had seen months earlier.

He had noticed it then because he had been trying to understand who the person beside it might be. At the time, the photograph had

offered almost nothing beyond a face and a vehicle. He had looked at it longer than necessary, closed it, and eventually stopped thinking about it.

Now he found himself wondering how old the motorcycle was.

He could not have said why that mattered.

Perhaps it did not.

He lowered his eyes to his notebook.

The teacher was explaining a shortcut. Utkarsh copied it carefully, then added a small note beside the calculation so that he would remember why it worked.

By the end of the class, he had completed every question.

Sanondita asked him about one of the answers. He showed her the relevant step, and they compared their calculations. She had made an error in the denominator. Once he pointed it out, she corrected the answer without difficulty.

“Got it,” she said.

He nodded.

She returned to her notebook.

He looked at the clock again.

That afternoon, Utkarsh remained at the coaching centre for another hour after the others began leaving.

He had planned to revise a chapter in mathematics before going home. The chapter was familiar enough that he expected to finish it quickly, but the questions were taking longer than usual.

He had begun preparing for government examinations while still in college. After his final examinations, preparation had become the main occupation of his days. There were days when the work gave him a reassuring sense of direction: a syllabus to follow, questions to practise, mock tests to analyse, and a timetable that could be adjusted whenever he fell behind.

He liked that arrangement.

A difficult problem could be revisited. A weak subject could be improved. Even a disappointing score offered information he could use the following morning.

He had no objection to beginning again when something went wrong.

What troubled him occasionally was that beginning again could look remarkably similar to standing still.

He turned a page.

The next question involved two people working at different rates. He wrote down the information, assigned variables, and began forming the equation.

Halfway through, he stopped.

He had been thinking about the examination calendar.

There was an application he needed to complete, another notification he had been waiting for, and a previous examination whose result had not yet been announced. The dates occupied different places in his mind, though none of them offered the certainty he wanted.

He opened his phone and checked the official website.

Nothing new.

He closed it.

For several minutes he continued solving questions, crossing out mistakes and rewriting figures where the calculations became untidy.

Then, without intending to, he wondered what Nayan did.

He knew almost nothing about him.

There had been photographs, comments beneath old posts, a name spoken in a classroom, and a few details that had reached him through Sanondita’s conversations. He could not have described Nayan’s work, his family, or even the kind of person he was.

It was strange to discover how much space a person could occupy in one’s thoughts while remaining almost entirely unknown.

Utkarsh rested his pen against the notebook.

Perhaps Nayan was older.

Perhaps he had begun working earlier.

Perhaps the car belonged to his family, or perhaps he had bought it with money he had earned himself.

Utkarsh had no idea.

He disliked that the possibilities interested him.

He looked down at his own handwriting.

A few months earlier, he would not have cared whether an unfamiliar person owned a motorcycle or a car. He had friends whose circumstances were very different from his, and he had never found it necessary to account for those differences. Some had started working after college. Others were preparing for examinations, studying further, or trying to decide what they wanted to do.

He had chosen his own course deliberately.

He still believed in it.

But that afternoon, the familiar explanation seemed to require more effort than usual.

He was preparing for a government job.

It was a perfectly reasonable answer when relatives asked what he was doing. It explained why he spent so much time studying, why he had not taken certain opportunities, and why he could speak confidently about an examination he had not yet passed.

He had said it often enough that the words came easily.

I'm preparing.

He looked at the question before him.

He knew what he wanted to become. He could describe the work, the responsibilities, even the life he hoped to arrange around it. But he could not say when any of it would begin.

For a moment, he tried to imagine meeting Sanondita several years later.

The thought arrived without a particular setting. He did not picture a reunion or an elaborate conversation. He imagined only being able to answer an ordinary question about his life without referring to something he was still waiting for.

Then he became conscious of what he was doing.

He had not been preparing for these examinations because of Sanondita. His plans had existed before he knew her name. The work mattered to him for reasons that had nothing to do with the people she knew.

He picked up his pen.

The question was still unfinished.

He worked through the remaining steps and reached an answer that did not match the one printed at the back of the book.

He began again.

When he left the coaching centre, the afternoon had already begun to soften towards evening.

The streets were crowded with people carrying shopping bags. A temporary arch had been erected across part of the road, and workers stood on ladders fastening strings of lights along its edges. At a nearby shop, two customers were arguing mildly over the size of a shirt while the salesman unfolded another from a shelf.

Utkarsh passed them without stopping.

He had received a message from Sanondita earlier, asking for the solution to a question from class. He had sent her a photograph of his notebook. She had thanked him.

He opened their conversation while waiting at a crossing.

There was nothing else to answer.

He scrolled upwards a little, past the photograph he had sent, then stopped.

He could ask her something about the approaching holidays.

He could ask whether she had finished her shopping, or whether she intended to visit any particular pandals. They had discussed Puja before. Such questions would not be unusual.

He typed, Any plans for Puja?

He read it once.

Then he deleted it.

There was no reason to make a conversation out of a question he was not sure he wanted answered.

He put the phone away.

A few minutes later, he checked the examination website again. There was still nothing new.

At home, he cleared a space on the desk and sat down with the two chapters he had intended to finish before dinner. The first took longer than expected. By the time he reached the second, he had to switch on the light.

Once, while checking an answer, he calculated how much time remained before the next examination. He knew the number of days already. Writing it down did not make the interval more useful. He turned to a fresh page and began another set of questions.

Outside, someone was testing a loudspeaker for the festival. A short burst of music rose above the traffic, stopped, and began again. He worked until the figures on the page lost their clarity.

Before sleeping, he checked his messages. There was nothing from Sanondita. He placed the phone face down, then turned it over again.

He had forgotten to put it on charge.

By the time Utkarsh left Kolkata, cloth and painted panels had concealed the bamboo frames along the roads. At familiar crossings, elaborate pandal entrances now interrupted his view of the street. Men worked from ladders beneath lights that would not be switched on until evening.

The holiday had entered nearly every conversation at coaching. Students spoke of going home, meeting friends, and returning to their studies afterward with a determination that few appeared entirely convinced by.

He was looking forward to home. He had missed the food, the familiar roads, the ease of entering a room where somebody would ask whether he had eaten before asking what he intended to become.

On the morning of his journey, he packed the last of his belongings and checked his bag twice. His new shirt lay folded between the others. He had taken more books than he was likely to

need, but there was still enough space for a few things he intended to bring back.

Outside, the city was already busy.

He found his seat among passengers carrying bags, gifts, and boxes of sweets. Across the aisle, a woman reminded her husband of something they had forgotten to buy. He suggested they could get it after arriving. She looked at the boxes already balanced between their feet and returned to counting them.

Beyond the window, smaller stations gave way to fields and ponds reflecting the pale sky. Kash flowers lifted their white plumes beside the tracks. He watched until his phone vibrated with messages from friends arranging to meet. One had sent a list of pandals; another insisted they begin early to avoid the crowds.

Utkarsh replied, then opened Sanondita’s conversation. His last exchange with her was still about a question from class. He locked the screen as a small station passed and returned to the window.

Home received him with the peculiar familiarity of a place that had continued existing perfectly well in his absence.

His family wanted to know whether he had eaten during the journey, whether he was tired, and why he had brought so many books when he was supposed to be home for the festival. He answered their questions, unpacked what was necessary, and left the rest for later.

By evening, the neighbourhood had begun to fill with people.

Some had returned from other towns and cities. Others were visiting relatives. Children ran along the road in new clothes, stopping whenever they heard a familiar voice calling from a nearby house. A group of boys were arranging lights across the entrance to a lane, arguing over whether the wires would reach the opposite side.

The first beats of dhaak reached Utkarsh from somewhere beyond the houses.

He had heard that sound every year for as long as he could remember. It belonged to the festival in a way that no decoration, however elaborate, could quite replace.

He stepped outside and stood for a moment beneath the evening sky.

A friend called him from the road.

They had plans for the following evening.

Utkarsh agreed to meet him.

For the first time in several weeks, there was nothing he needed to hurry towards.

On Saptami evening, he went out with his friends.

They met near a familiar crossing, where a temporary arch of coloured lights had been erected above the road. The lights formed patterns that appeared to travel from one end of the arch to the other, disappearing and beginning again. Beneath them, people moved in both directions, some walking towards the pandals and others returning with tired children and packets of food.

His friends were already discussing their route.

One wanted to visit the largest pandal first. Another insisted they begin with the smaller neighbourhood celebrations. A third had heard about an unusual theme some distance away.

“We’ll finish the festival here,” Utkarsh said, “deciding where to start.”

“You choose, then.”

He pointed down the road.

“Why that way?”

“We’re already facing it.”

They found enough wrong with this reasoning to discuss it while walking in the direction he had chosen. Utkarsh joined in, relieved by the ease of being contradicted by people who had been doing it for years.

Shops had extended their counters towards the pavement. The smell of frying food mingled with incense. At one corner, a little

girl kept pointing to a balloon while her father searched the crowd for someone. A family farther ahead had stopped for a photograph; the youngest child refused to stand where he was told. His mother rearranged everyone around the place he had chosen.

At the first pandal, the queue moved slowly between temporary barriers. The entrance had been decorated with intricate patterns, and soft golden light fell across the faces of the people waiting beneath it. Somewhere inside, the steady rhythm of dhaak rose above the crowd.

His friends were discussing the decorations when the queue began moving again.

They entered together.

The idol stood beneath an elaborate canopy, surrounded by flowers, lamps, and carefully arranged details that drew the eye from one part of the structure to another. The light softened the colours of the figures and caught along the edges of their ornaments. Incense hung faintly in the air.

For a moment, Utkarsh forgot about the people pressing forward behind him.

He looked at the face of the goddess.

He had seen countless Durga idols over the years, yet the first proper visit of Puja still carried something of the anticipation he remembered from childhood. He could recall waiting impatiently for the evenings when he would be allowed to go out, returning home exhausted, and waking the next morning already thinking about where they would go next.

One of his friends touched his shoulder.

“Come on. They’re asking us to move.”

Utkarsh stepped aside.

Outside, they stopped to look at the photographs they had taken.

Someone complained that the lighting had made every picture too bright. Another insisted they could take better photographs later.

Utkarsh looked at one of the images on his friend’s phone.

Behind their faces, the illuminated entrance was almost completely hidden.

They took another photograph.

This time, he smiled before anyone asked him to.

As the evening grew more crowded, they walked through neighbourhoods he knew well, transformed by hanging lamps and coloured fabric stretched overhead. At a food stall, they compared the pandals they had visited. Utkarsh defended a smaller one they had passed earlier against a friend who appeared to believe beauty could be measured by the length of the queue.

“You liked that one because we didn’t have to wait,” the friend said.

“That was one of its many artistic achievements.”

The discussion continued over their food. Someone mentioned a teacher from school, and soon each of them was correcting the others’ account of an incident they all claimed to remember perfectly. Utkarsh laughed so hard at one correction that he had to put his plate down. For a few minutes, he wanted nothing beyond another helping and for the story to continue.

A little later, while they waited for one friend to finish eating, he took out his phone to check the time.

A photograph appeared near the top of his Instagram feed.

He recognised one of the places in Kolkata from the decorations.

He looked at the photograph, then at the location beneath it.

For a moment, he wondered whether Sanondita had been there.

She might be at home, with her family, or somewhere else entirely. He scrolled past, then returned to the image and enlarged the crowd behind the people posing.

He knew how little chance there was of finding her. His thumb moved the photograph sideways anyway, bringing another row of strangers into view.

There was nothing to see.

“Utkarsh.”

He looked up.

His friends had begun walking.

“Coming?”

“Yes.”

He locked his phone and caught up with them.

They were deciding where to go next.

He listened to their suggestions and chose one of the routes.

For the next half hour, he did not look at his phone.

By the time they reached another pandal, it was well past nine.

The entrance was crowded, and a long queue curved along the road. The decorations were visible above the heads of the waiting visitors, their colours changing as the lights moved through a programmed sequence.

Utkarsh stood with his friends near the barriers.

A couple a few places ahead were trying to take a photograph together. The man held the phone at arm’s length, but the woman kept pointing towards the illuminated entrance behind them. He adjusted the angle, took the photograph, and showed it to her.

She shook her head.

They tried again.

Utkarsh looked away.

He wondered where Sanondita was spending the evening and took out his phone.

How’s Puja going?

He had not typed it yet. He could imagine her sending a photograph, complaining about a queue, telling him she was out with friends. Then he imagined a name following the answer, and the question no longer seemed easy.

Their last exchange was still visible. She had thanked him for a solution; he had answered. Nothing on the screen prevented him from writing again. He rested his thumb near the message field while the queue moved forward.

Someone behind asked them to close the gap. He followed his friends and put the phone away. The opportunity remained

available in his pocket. For the next few steps, that was worse than having missed it.

Inside, the sound of dhaak grew louder.

The pandal had been designed around a traditional courtyard, with columns, hanging lamps, and a carefully painted background. The idol stood at the far end, illuminated by a warm light that made the surrounding crowd appear darker.

His friends moved towards the side where visitors were allowed to take photographs.

Utkarsh remained a little behind them.

He watched a family approach the idol. An elderly woman stood with her hands joined for several moments while the younger members of the family waited nearby. A small boy, unable to see past the adults, rose on his toes and held on to his father's arm.

The father lifted him.

The boy looked towards the goddess, then turned to say something into his father's ear.

Utkarsh could not hear what he said.

He found himself thinking of Sanondita again.

Not of any particular photograph or conversation.

He wondered whether she was tired. Whether she had eaten. Whether she had found a place she especially liked. Whether, at some point during the evening, she had stood before an idol and remained there a little longer than the people around her.

He knew none of these things.

He could not even be certain she had gone out.

One of his friends called him over for a photograph.

He joined them.

The picture was taken, and they moved on.

The streets were still crowded when they began the journey home.

It was close to midnight. Some food stalls were closing, while others remained surrounded by customers. Children slept against their parents' shoulders. Groups of young people continued walking

towards the next pandal, apparently determined to see as much as possible before morning.

His friends discussed meeting again on Ashtami.

Utkarsh agreed.

They separated at the crossing where they had met earlier.

He walked the remaining distance home alone.

The lights above the road were still on. From somewhere nearby came the faint sound of music, interrupted occasionally by an announcement over a loudspeaker.

He passed houses where people were sitting outside, talking in the late-night air. A few children were still awake, playing beneath the decorations.

When he reached home, he found that everyone had either gone to bed or was preparing to.

He washed his face and changed his clothes.

His feet ached from walking.

He sat on the edge of the bed and opened the photographs from the evening.

There were dozens.

In some, his friends stood beneath illuminated entrances. In others, the idols appeared surrounded by flowers and intricate decorations. Several photographs were blurred, and one showed little more than the backs of people’s heads.

He stopped at a picture taken inside the second pandal.

He remembered the long queue, the changing lights, and the boy being lifted by his father.

He remembered taking out his phone.

He could not remember much of the decorations themselves.

He moved to the next photograph.

Then the next.

A message arrived in the group his friends had created for Puja. Someone had sent another photograph and suggested they visit a different part of town the following evening.

Utkarsh replied that he would be there.

He opened Instagram.

Several people he knew had posted photographs from Kolkata. There were crowded streets, illuminated pandals, and familiar faces standing beneath decorations he had never seen before.

He moved through them slowly.

Sanondita had not posted anything new that he could see.

He checked her profile.

Then he closed it.

He lay down with the light still on. He had enjoyed the evening. He could remember laughing at the food stall, the anticipation before the first idol, the familiar irritation of waiting for his friends to agree on a direction. Yet one of the clearest memories was of standing in a queue with an empty message field open.

He considered writing in the morning. There would be time then, without people waiting for him to move.

When he next checked the clock, it was past one. A distant dhaak continued beyond the houses. He turned off the light and pictured Kolkata as he had left it, the workers fastening lights to frames. By now, all of them would be illuminated.

He wondered which ones she had seen, then turned towards the wall.

On Ashtami morning, Utkarsh woke to the sound of dhaak.

It came from the neighbourhood pandal, carried through the open spaces between houses, rising and falling beneath the ordinary sounds of a household beginning its day. Someone was speaking in the next room. Water ran from a tap. From the road came the voice of a man calling to someone across the street.

He remained in bed until a message from his friends reminded him that they intended to leave earlier that evening. His feet still ached. He replied that he would be ready.

By late morning, people were moving towards the neighbourhood pandal in fresh clothes, carrying flowers and

offerings. Announcements reached the house between bursts of drums, the words lost before he could make them out.

He went out with his family.

The pandal was crowded, but the movement of people was unhurried. Some stood before the idol with folded hands. Others waited for relatives, adjusted the clothes of restless children, or stepped aside to make room for those approaching with offerings.

Utkarsh stood among them.

He had visited the pandal the previous evening, but daylight revealed details he had scarcely noticed: the painted patterns along the pillars, the flowers arranged around the platform, the marks left by countless feet on the temporary flooring.

He watched a priest prepare for the next part of the worship.

Beside him, an elderly man closed his eyes and remained still for several moments.

Utkarsh lowered his gaze.

He had grown up with these mornings. There had been years when he had been impatient for the evening celebrations to begin, when the rituals seemed to take far longer than necessary and every hour spent at home felt like time lost.

Now he was content to stand there.

When his family began moving towards the exit, he followed.

Outside, someone he had known since childhood recognised him and stopped to ask about his studies.

“How’s the preparation going?”

“It’s going well.”

“When’s the next exam?”

Utkarsh told him.

The man nodded, wished him luck, and continued towards the pandal.

Utkarsh walked home with his family.

He had answered the questions so often that he scarcely needed to think about the words anymore.

That evening, his friends took him to a part of town they had not visited the previous night.

The streets were brighter, the crowds thicker, and the queues longer. At one pandal, they waited nearly forty minutes before reaching the entrance. Another was so crowded that they decided to return later, though none of them seriously believed they would.

They ate at a roadside stall, walked beneath rows of coloured lights, and stopped to watch a group of dhakis playing near a pandal entrance.

Utkarsh enjoyed the performance.

The drummers moved with the rhythm, the large instruments swinging from their shoulders as the sound gathered force. People had formed a loose circle around them. A few children tried to imitate the movements, and their parents watched from behind.

One of his friends began recording.

Utkarsh stood quietly, listening until the performance ended.

Later, they entered a pandal where the lighting had been arranged to resemble a night sky. Small points of light covered the ceiling, and the pathway curved towards the idol through a series of decorated arches.

It was one of the most beautiful pandals he had seen that year.

He took several photographs.

When he looked through them afterward, he found that none had captured the place as he remembered it.

He tried another angle, then put his phone away.

His friends had moved towards the exit.

He followed them into the crowd.

Near the road, they stopped while one of them answered a call.

Utkarsh looked around.

A group of young women passed, discussing the pandal they had just visited. One was showing the others a photograph on her phone. Farther along the pavement, two boys were trying to decide whether they had enough time to visit another place before midnight.

He wondered how far Sanondita had walked that evening.

The thought surprised him less than it had the previous night.

He knew the roads around her part of Kolkata. He could picture the traffic, the crowded crossings, the queues extending beyond pandal entrances. He had seen photographs of the celebrations appearing online since morning.

But when he tried to imagine her among those crowds, the picture would not settle.

He could see the streets.

He could not see her.

“Shall we go?” one of his friends asked.

Utkarsh turned.

“Yes.”

They crossed the road together.

He did not take out his phone.

Navami passed quickly.

He spent part of the morning at home, attempted a few practice questions, and abandoned them when relatives arrived. Later, he went out again.

By then, the festival had acquired the particular restlessness of something approaching its end. People who had postponed visiting certain pandals were suddenly determined to see them all. Roads remained crowded late into the night. Conversations were full of places still to be visited and plans that could no longer be fitted into the time remaining.

Utkarsh stayed out with his friends until late.

They revisited a pandal they had particularly liked, bought food from a stall they remembered from the previous year, and took photographs beneath an arch that would soon be dismantled.

For a while, he was entirely occupied with the evening.

Then, while his friends were discussing where to eat, he noticed a missed call from someone at home.

He called back, explained that he would return later, and ended the conversation.

Before putting the phone away, he opened his messages.

He had not spoken to Sanondita since leaving Kolkata.

Much of their friendship happened because they sat beside each other. A difficult question, somebody's expression, a page turned towards him: a conversation could begin before he had decided to begin one. Here, choosing a photograph felt like choosing how to appear in the middle of her evening.

He selected one, then returned to their conversation without attaching it. He told himself he could find a better picture. There were dozens in his gallery. He did not look for another.

His friends called him over.

He locked the screen and joined them.

By the time he reached home, he had forgotten about the photograph.

He remembered it again while getting ready for bed.

He left it unsent.

On Dashami, the neighbourhood began to change.

The decorations were still standing, the lights remained in place, and the pandal was crowded from morning. Yet the conversations had grown quieter in places. People spoke of returning to work, reopening shops, and travelling back to the cities where they studied or earned their living.

In the afternoon, Utkarsh visited the pandal once more.

He stood before the idol for a while.

The flowers were beginning to lose their freshness. The floor bore the marks of several days of visitors. Someone nearby was gathering discarded paper cups into a large bag.

He remembered the first evening, when everything had seemed newly illuminated.

It had been only a few days.

Outside, the afternoon light fell across the road. Children were still playing beneath the decorations, and people continued arriving, unwilling to let the day pass without another visit.

Utkarsh remained until his family was ready to leave.

Later, the sounds of farewell and immersion carried through the neighbourhood. The festival's brightness had not disappeared, but it no longer seemed to promise another evening exactly like the last.

He helped with a few things at home, spoke to relatives, and began arranging his belongings for the journey back.

His books were almost as neatly packed as they had been when he arrived.

He had studied less than he intended.

He told himself he would make up the hours in Kolkata.

That evening, while folding his clothes, he found the shirt he had bought before Puja.

He had worn it once.

He folded it and placed it in the bag.

His phone vibrated.

For a moment, he looked towards it before reaching for the screen.

It was a message from one of his friends, asking when he would leave.

He replied.

Then he returned to packing.

The journey back to Kolkata was quieter. Passengers still carried bags and boxes of sweets, but now they discussed work, classes, the days ahead. At one station, Utkarsh noticed a child asleep against his mother with a small paper toy resting in his lap.

He took out a book, read the same paragraph twice, and closed it. His phone held photographs from nearly every evening. He had plans to meet his friends when he next returned. Home had given him the things he had missed, though he had spent some of those hours thinking about a person who was not there.

Now he imagined showing Sanondita the photographs in class. He would not have to choose one in advance. She could take the phone, move through them herself, ask him to explain a place. He might hear about her Puja while she looked.

He opened his book again. This time, he managed several pages.

Kolkata greeted him with the untidy aftermath of celebration.

The elaborate entrances still stood above some roads, though several had already begun to lose their decorations. Workers were removing lights from temporary frames. At a few places, bamboo poles lay stacked beside the pavement, waiting to be carried away.

Shops had reopened. Buses moved through streets that had recently belonged almost entirely to pedestrians. The city was returning to its ordinary impatience.

Utkarsh reached his room, unpacked the things he needed, and set his books on the desk.

He had class the following morning.

He checked the schedule, arranged his notes, and went to bed earlier than he had during the festival.

The next day, students were comparing Puja experiences when he entered the classroom. Someone who had returned that morning looked as though he had scarcely slept. Utkarsh greeted a few familiar faces and took his usual seat.

He placed his notebook on the desk and glanced towards the entrance. There were still several minutes before class. Students continued arriving; the room filled with voices, scraping chairs, bags being dropped. He opened his book, keeping a finger on the page he intended to revise.

The teacher entered. Sanondita had not arrived.

He uncapped his pen. Perhaps she was returning later, or had something to do at home. For the first few minutes, he listened for a late arrival taking the place beside him. Then a question on the board required his attention, and he missed the next opening of the door.

During the break, he checked his phone. He considered asking whether she had returned to Kolkata before remembering that he did not know whether she had left. A classmate came over with a question. Utkarsh turned his notebook towards him and explained the method.

By the second class, he had stopped looking towards the entrance. He packed his books afterward and left beneath an arch from which workers were removing the lights. On the journey back, he had imagined a conversation so ordinary that it had hardly felt like something he was hoping for.

He could still have it another day.

Sanondita did not come the following day either.

During the break, he checked whether she had posted anything online, then closed the application and opened their conversation.

Are you coming to class?

He deleted it. The class had already begun. He tried again.

Didn't see you in class. Everything okay?

He read the message once.

It was a perfectly ordinary thing to ask.

He sent it.

He returned to a question while he waited. A little later, the screen lit up.

Yeah, everything's fine. Couldn't come.

Okay. Just checking.

She acknowledged the message. He was relieved, and then became aware that he had wanted something after the reassurance: a reason, a date when she would return, a question about his holidays. He read her answer once more before putting the phone away.

The teacher had given them a new set of questions. He completed the first, checked it, and moved on. When he stood to leave, he discovered that his notebook had spread onto the other half of the desk.

He drew it back, put it in his bag, and left with the others.

By the end of October, the regular timetable had replaced the holiday schedule. Teachers hurried unfinished chapters towards completion. The students who had promised themselves discipline after Puja were discovering the difficulty of keeping the promise.

Each morning, a little more of the bamboo frame near the crossing had disappeared. First the coloured panels, then the lights, then the fabric concealing the structure. Eventually, only a few poles lay beside the road. Utkarsh passed them on his way to classes and spent his evenings recording mistakes from practice papers. He had made a rule: an incorrect answer was not finished with until he understood why he had given it.

On Monday, Sanondita was absent. He revised before the lesson and put his notes away when the teacher arrived. He was beginning to work without first waiting to find out whether she would come.

On Tuesday, she was there before him.

“Finally.”

He glanced at the clock. “Class hasn’t started.”

“I know.”

She moved her notebook to make room. He put his bag on the floor and sat down, absurdly pleased to have his punctuality questioned.

“Did you do yesterday’s questions?”

“Most.”

“Show me the last two.”

He opened his notebook. She followed the calculations with the end of her pen, tucking a few strands of hair behind her ear without looking away. He turned the page towards her.

“Here. This is where the values change.”

“Oh. I was using the earlier value.”

“That would give you a different answer.”

She began correcting it. He took out his pen. For a while, neither needed to speak.

During the break, she asked about Puja.

“How was it at home?”

“Good.”

“Did you go out?”

“Almost every evening.”

“Every evening?”

“Nearly.”

“Then you must have taken photographs.”

“A few.”

“Show me.”

He opened his gallery. She moved through the pictures, asking where a pandal was, commenting on a decoration. He watched her discover the evenings he had almost written to her about. Here was the photograph he had considered sending. She passed it, paused at another, and asked him to go back.

“The previous one.”

“This?”

“Yes. That’s beautiful.”

The ceiling had been arranged like a night sky. He had forgotten taking the photograph from that angle.

“The whole ceiling was covered with lights. It looked better in person.”

“It always does.”

She looked a moment longer before handing back the phone. He had spent days unable to choose a picture for her; she had found one she liked in less than a minute.

“Did you go anywhere?” he asked.

“Yes, I went out.”

“Where?”

“A few places around Kolkata.”

“Was it crowded?”

“Very.”

She described a long queue and a pandal she had liked, then found a photograph of its idol and illuminated entrance. He leaned towards the screen.

"It looks beautiful."

"It was."

She put the phone away. He wanted to ask who had accompanied her. There was time; the next teacher had not arrived. But she was telling him something else about the festival, and he found that he could either listen or prepare the question. He looked back at her and listened.

For days, he had wanted to hear about her evening. Now she was telling him. He would have to decide what to do with the part she had not offered, but he need not lose this part while waiting for it.

She stayed for the next class. They worked through the reasoning questions together, disagreeing about a method until she pointed to his calculation.

"You've written the wrong number."

He looked. She was right.

"The method was excellent," he said.

"For a different question."

He corrected the number. She waited for him to finish, then compared their answers again. They matched this time.

At the end of class, she checked the time and began packing.

"I have to go. Send me the remaining questions?"

"I will."

"Thanks."

He looked up. "Will you come tomorrow?"

"I'll try."

"All right."

He sent the questions that evening and received her thanks. By Thursday, the chair was empty again. He remembered her answer while opening his textbook, then put his phone away when the lesson began.

During the break, a student from another row approached.

“Is anyone sitting here?”

“No.”

The student sat down to ask about the previous lesson. Halfway through explaining it, Utkarsh realised he had left very little room for the other notebook and moved his things closer. The student thanked him and remained for the next class.

Twice, Utkarsh turned slightly to show him a calculation before remembering that the person beside him needed a different explanation. He corrected himself. The student followed the method and asked another question. Utkarsh answered it, grateful for something specific to attend to.

Over the next few days, Sanondita came once, missed two classes, then appeared again. When she was there, conversation was easy. They discussed preparation, her students, things that had annoyed or amused them. He could enjoy an entire exchange before remembering to wonder when they would have another.

Her absences were becoming a pattern without becoming an explanation. He remembered her mentioning work, or saying she was busy. At the time, he had answered and moved on. Now he returned to the remarks as though attention paid afterward might supply what he had not asked.

One afternoon, after another missed class, he photographed the notes for her. She had not requested them. He paused over the attachments, then sent them; she would have use for the explanation whether or not it began a conversation.

Thank you so much.

He smiled at her reply.

No problem.

That evening, he completed a mock test and spent nearly an hour reviewing the questions he had missed. He was pleased with the work. He also knew how differently he might have approached it had her reply not arrived. He left the phone where it was and finished marking the paper before checking tomorrow’s timetable.

The following morning, he arrived early and began revising questions marked the night before. The room was quiet. When he heard a bag being set down and footsteps approaching, he continued reading.

"Utkarsh."

He looked up. Sanondita stood beside the desk.

"Move your bag."

"Oh. Sorry."

He lifted it from the chair to the floor. She sat down.

"Have you started the new chapter?"

"A little."

"Is it difficult?"

"Not really. The first part is easy."

"Good. I've missed enough already."

He showed her where to begin. She followed his explanation, then started working independently. He returned to his own questions, aware of the page turning beside him, her pen stopping, the small pause before she asked something. He had spent several mornings adjusting to their absence. They returned so easily that he wondered why the adjustment had cost him anything.

During the final class, a message arrived on her phone. She read it and placed the screen face down. A few minutes later, she checked it again. He noticed the movement, then brought his attention back to the board.

"What did he say after this?" she whispered.

He showed her the next line.

"Thanks."

Her phone remained beside the notebook. He could remember the step he had shown her, but not the one the teacher had explained while he was watching her return to her work. He waited until the calculation was finished and copied the missing line.

As they packed, she said, "I might not come tomorrow."

"Okay."

“I have some work. Will you send me the notes?”

“Of course.”

“Thank you.”

She smiled, and he smiled back. After she left, he checked the final calculation. He had copied it correctly. He closed the notebook and went home by the crossing where the Puja entrance had stood.

The bamboo was gone. Traffic moved through the space without slowing. Waiting for the signal, he remembered her voice that morning: Move your bag. The impatience had contained an ordinary certainty that she could sit beside him. He was still glad to have heard it. Tomorrow’s absence did not take the morning away, although he found himself wishing she had told him later.

At home, he photographed the final solution before beginning his preparation for the next day.

She did not come. He put his bag on the floor and opened his notebook. That morning he had decided to resolve a type of question on which he kept making small mistakes. He followed the first example, then the second. When the teacher asked whether anyone had doubts, he raised his hand.

The explanation took less than a minute. He wrote down the step and tried the next problem alone. This time the answer was right. By the end of the lesson he had completed the exercise, and during the break he remained to check his working.

“Coming?” somebody asked from the doorway.

“In a minute.”

He finished the last calculation before remembering the notes. There were six photographs. He checked that each was legible, attached them, and wrote:

Today’s class notes.

Then he went outside.

Sanondita replied that afternoon while he was working through a practice paper.

Thank you.

Was the chapter difficult?

Not too difficult. The last part needs a little practice.

Okay. I'll see.

If you get stuck, tell me.

She thanked him again. He left the conversation there and finished the paper. When he marked it, he found fewer mistakes than usual. He counted them again and wrote the score at the top.

His phone lay beside the notebook. He looked at it, tempted to tell her. There was no new message, and he returned to the questions he had underlined. The score remained good while nobody else knew about it. He was pleased enough to begin another paper.

The next morning, he arrived early again. A tea seller outside was arranging glasses while a customer read his phone and allowed his tea to cool. Upstairs, Utkarsh took his place and began reviewing his mistakes.

When footsteps approached, he looked up. A classmate wanted to see the homework. They discussed it for a few minutes, and the classmate returned to his seat. There were still ten minutes before the lesson.

Utkarsh glanced at the entrance, then lowered his eyes to the page. He had begun to recognise the difference between expecting someone and hoping they would arrive. Expectation had once allowed him to open his book without looking at the door. Hope kept interrupting to tell him there was still time.

Sanondita came the following week. He was copying a question when she entered and finished the line before looking up.

"Is anyone sitting here?"

"No."

She sat down and opened her notebook.

"Have I missed much?"

"A few chapters."

"That much?"

"Not all of them are difficult."

“Good. You’ll have to help me.”

“I will.”

He moved his notebook so that she could see the question. They worked as they had before: an explanation, a disagreement, a calculation checked together. Her voice beside him made the classroom feel familiar again, though he had attended every day she had missed.

During the break, she described a child she taught who had struggled with a question she considered simple. She had tried explaining it another way and still had not reached him. Utkarsh asked what she had tried, listened, and suggested a different approach.

She considered it. “That might work.”

“Try it.”

“I will.”

She made a note on her phone. He watched her write down the suggestion. He knew her as the person who asked about a missed step; the child knew her as the person expected to explain it. He hoped it would help them both.

Then she asked about his preparation.

“Better,” he said.

“Really?”

“I’ve been improving in the mocks.”

“That’s good.”

He began describing a question he had finally learned to solve. Partway through, he saw that she was smiling at his pleasure rather than following every step. He stopped before reaching the last calculation.

“You’ll clear it,” she said.

He looked at her.

“I hope so.”

“You will.”

He smiled back. She had no result to offer him, no knowledge of what would happen. Yet he wanted to hold on to the ease with

which she had said it, as though his future looked less doubtful from her side of the desk.

“There’s another question I wanted to show you,” he said.

“Which one?”

He pointed to the page. The break ended before they finished.

After the final class, he asked whether she would come tomorrow.

“I’m not sure. I have a few things to finish.”

“Okay.”

“Send me the homework if I don’t come?”

“Of course.”

“Thank you.”

They left together. Where their routes separated, she turned towards him.

“Bye, Utkarsh.”

“Bye.”

He watched until she turned the corner, then continued towards the road.

That evening, Utkarsh was halfway through the second section of a mock test when he remembered her saying he would clear the examination.

He stopped with a calculation unfinished. Outside, vehicles passed, someone spoke loudly on a phone, and a television played in a neighbouring house. He had been working steadily for nearly an hour. Now he imagined a result worth telling her about.

He would send a message. Perhaps she would call. He could hear how pleased she might sound and began arranging what he would say, although he had neither a result nor any reason to practise the conversation yet.

The thought carried him beyond the call. A job, money he had earned, an answer when someone asked what he was doing. He imagined meeting her without referring to a future still waiting to begin. And somewhere in that imagined meeting, she stayed longer.

He looked down at the paper.

She had encouraged him to pass an examination. She had not said that passing would change anything between them. He knew how quietly he had supplied the rest. Even now, recognising it, he wanted to return to the conversation he had invented and hear her ask him to stay.

The question before him was one he knew how to solve. He finished the calculation, checked the answer, and continued. His plans had existed before he knew her. He wanted them still, though he could no longer always separate that wanting from the wish to have something good to tell her.

Later, after marking the test, he opened the class group for the following week’s schedule. Sanondita’s conversation was near the top when he returned to the main screen. He opened it and scrolled past notes, homework, brief exchanges that had begun without either of them deciding they mattered.

One message detained him. He could not remember what had prompted it. He tried to recover the afternoon around the words: her notebook open beside his, her phone set down, the expression she might have worn. At the time, he had expected another ordinary conversation to follow. He had not thought to remember this one properly.

He put the phone down. On the desk, the marked paper waited beside his list of mistakes. There were things he could improve before the examination. He could return to a chapter, learn a method, stop making an error he now understood. The work did not guarantee a result, but it gave him somewhere to begin.

Sanondita might not come tomorrow. No amount of preparation could settle that before morning.

He sat for a while, then opened his notes. He wanted her to be there. He also wanted to understand the question he had marked, and for the next few minutes he gave it his attention.

The next day, he arrived before most of the students.

The classroom was almost empty.

He went to his usual desk and placed his bag on the floor.

There were two chairs.

He sat in one.

He took out his notebook, his pen, and the book he intended to revise.

Then he looked at the other chair.

For a moment, he considered moving his bag onto it.

There was no reason to leave the place unused. If another student needed somewhere to sit, he would move his things anyway.

He lifted the bag.

He held it for a moment.

Then he placed it beneath his own chair.

He opened his notebook.

The first question was difficult, and he had to work through it twice before finding the correct answer.

More students began arriving.

Someone greeted him.

He answered.

The room filled gradually with voices, the sound of chairs moving, and the rustle of pages being turned.

Utkarsh kept working.

When the teacher entered, he looked towards the front and uncapped his pen.

The chair beside him was still empty.

He moved his notebook a little closer to himself, leaving enough space for another one.

Then he wrote down the date and began the lesson.